G. Thompson) Burnside's conjecture that every group of odd order is solvable. Another seminal conjecture, Burnside's Problem, related to the structure of torsion groups, has preoccupied group theory and representation theory specialists for over a century, yielding the 1994 Fields Medal to Efim Zelmanov for the solution of its restricted version.

The appreciation of the beauty of Burnside's work took quite a while. His employment at the Royal Naval College separated him geographically from his university colleagues. He apparently had no "extensive direct contacts with other mathematicians interested in the subject (of group theory). It appears that he worked in isolation, possibly even more so than was normal for his times, with little opportunity (or, perhaps, inclination) to discuss his ideas with others", according to his biographer [**41**, p. 32]. Burnside taught several generations of navy officers but created no mathematical school of his own.

In December 1925 Burnside suffered a stroke, and his doctor forbade him, among other unhealthy activities, from doing mathematics. Burnside naturally disobeyed and did not live very long. His obituary in the London *Evening News* barely mentioned his mathematical studies but reported that "rowing men will regret to hear of the death of W. Burnside, one of the best known Cambridge athletes of his day" (quoted in [**11**, p. 96]).

Shortly before his death Burnside answered a query from a young mathematician named Philip Hall, who asked for advice on topics of group theory. Burnside sent him a postcard listing a few problems worth investigating. This message in a bottle, thrown into the sea, miraculously found a perfect addressee. The same volume of the *Journal of the London Mathematical Society* that contained Burnside's obituary featured Hall's "Note on Soluble Groups", which marked the beginning of his lifetime career in this field. Hall eventually succeeded Burnside as the chief promoter of group theory in England. "The aim of my researches", he later wrote, "has been to a very considerable extent that of extending and completing in certain directions the work of Burnside" (quoted in [**11**, p. 96]).